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Six Flags Magic Mountain's X2 welcomed 16 million riders since its opening in 2008. The ride was permanently closed Tuesday. **COURTESY OF MAGIC MOUNTAIN**

X2

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"While X2 consistently passed a multitude of safety tests, we have decided to close the ride because we believe it's the right thing to do," Oerding said in a Six Flags blog post. "Ride safety is a cornerstone of our business and when we see guest confidence affected, we take it seriously."

X2 has welcomed 16 million riders and earned a passionate following among ride enthusiasts since opening in 2008, according to Oerding.

"Our purpose is to create fun, thrills and a lifetime of memories by creating unforgettable experiences that are underpinned by comprehensive safety policies," Oerding said in the Six Flags blog post.

Magic Mountain temporarily closed X2 on July 12 following an incident involving the coaster that is under investigation by state safety officials.

The 200-foot-tall X2 reaches a top speed of 76 mph while navigating a pair of raven turn inversions over a 3,600-foot-long track. The 360-degree rotating seats on the wing coaster extend on either side of the track.

More than 100 riders on X2 at Six Flags Magic Mountain allege they suffered traumatic brain injuries on the coaster, according to lawsuits and pending lawsuits by a Los Angeles law firm.

The Dordick law firm announced the filing of three lawsuits on Sept. 22 alleging catastrophic brain damage by three clients who rode X2.

Dordick is representing Naomi Greer-Wilkinson, Pamela Guillen and Michael Wilk in the X2 lawsuits.

Greer-Wilkinson, 25, of Los Angeles, and Guillen, 40, of Hawaii, were both treated for severe brain hemorrhages within days of each other in July after riding X2, according to Dordick attorney Christopher Bulone.

Wilk, a 68-year-old insurance defense attorney from Calabasas, was treated for an acute brain bleed and underwent multiple surgeries after riding X2 in February, according to Bulone.

"Closing the ride protects future guests and we welcome that," attorney Gary Dordick said in a statement. "But it does nothing for the people who have already been hurt. Six Flags must now take responsibility for them."

A CNN investigation found X2 was linked to two deaths and more than a dozen reports of serious injuries over two decades after a review of legal filings, depositions and medical records.

Anne and William Hawley of Garden Grove alleged in a 2024 lawsuit that the "unreasonably dangerous" X2 coaster caused their 22-year-old son Christopher's fatal brain injury. The family settled the case with Magic Mountain and X2 trainmaker S&S Worldwide in August before the trial started, according to KTTV Fox 11 News.

Six Flags and S&S Worldwide denied liability and the settlement did not include any finding X2 was defective or the companies caused Hawley's death, according to the Dordick law firm website.

Hilda Farias, 28, died in 2010 from a brain abnormality that ruptured allegedly because of the intensity of X2, according to the CNN investigation. A lawsuit by the family was settled for an undisclosed amount, according to CNN.

Every Six Flags ride undergoes extensive inspections by state, insurance, engineering, safety and third-party inspectors designed to meet or exceed manufacturer requirements and industry standards, according to the company website.

GABRIEL

From Page 1

civilians by immigration officers, according to Gabriel's office.

The measure builds on a state law enacted in 2020 requiring the Attorney General's Office to investigate fatal police shootings of unarmed civilians. Under AB 1806, if an investigation finds that an immigration officer violated state law, the state prosecutor is authorized to prosecute the case, and the findings must be made public in a written report.

AB 1807, also co-authored by Assemblyman Juan Carrillo, D-Palmdale, prohibits state-owned property, including parking lots, vacant lots and garages, from being used to stage, process, detain or otherwise support federal immigration enforcement operations.

The measure also requires state agencies to identify properties that could be used for such operations, post signs, limit access and develop procedures intended to prevent unauthorized federal immigration enforcement activity on state property.

"California must continue to push back against the Trump Administration to protect our immigrant communities and our constitutional rights," Gabriel said in a statement.

"I'm proud that AB 1807 will prohibit federal immigration agents from using state property for immigration enforcement, while AB 1806 will require an independent, transparent, and thorough state investigation when an immigration officer fatally shoots an unarmed civilian. Together, these new laws will strengthen the rule of law and protect the people who call our state home."

Gabriel's office said the legislation was developed in response to federal immigration enforcement operations in Los Angeles and elsewhere around the country.

"As the author of the landmark legislation that created independent investigations into police shootings (AB 1506, 2020), I applaud Assemblymember Gabriel and Gov.Newsom for expanding this important accountability measure to include actions by immigration officers through AB 1806," Sacramento Mayor Kevin McCarty said in a statement.

Carrillo said AB 1807 was intended to prevent federal agents from using state resources to conduct immigration enforcement operations.

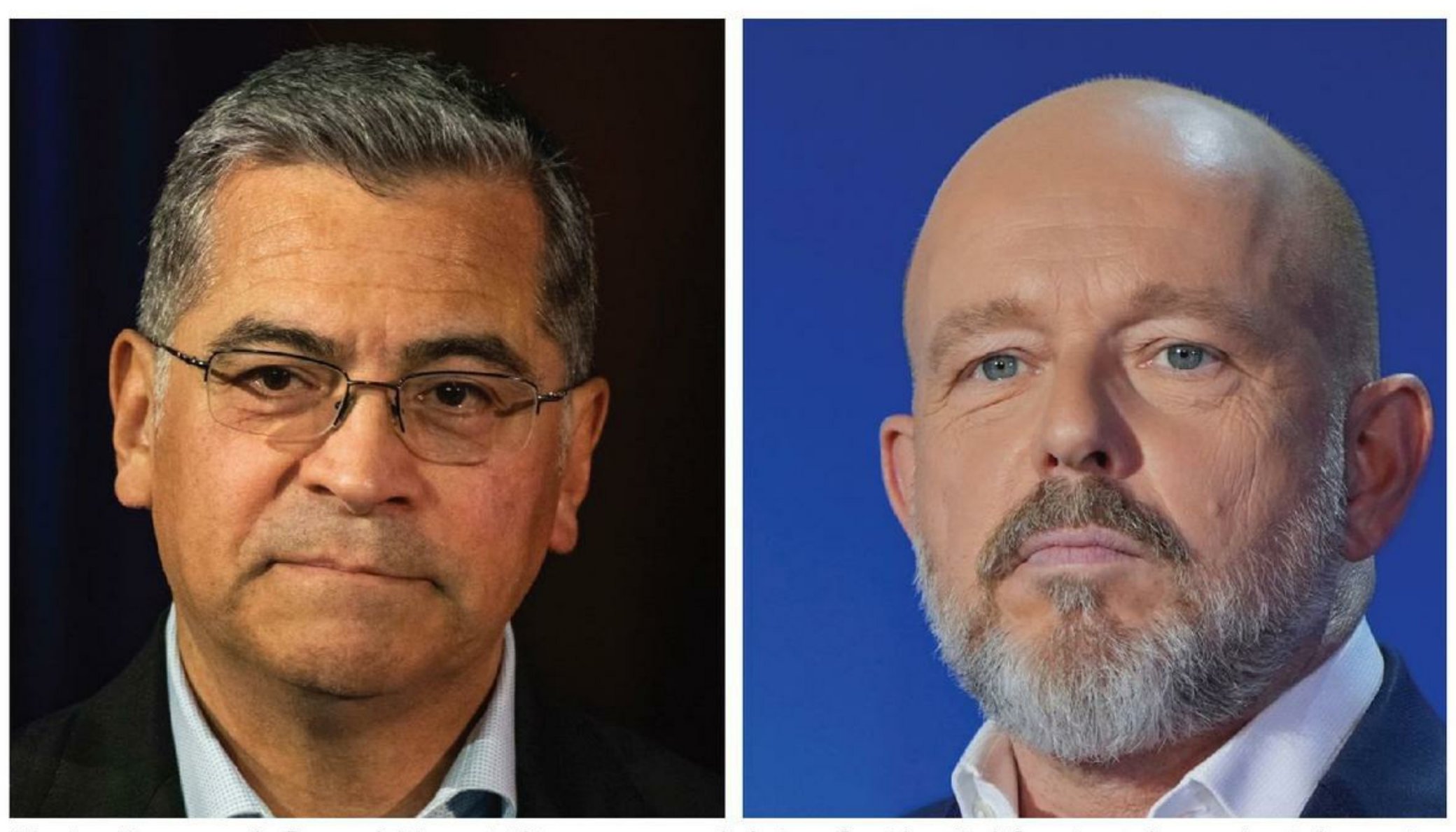
"What we are seeing throughout our nation is a result of an administration that has normalized fear, intimidation, and use of force in our communities. That is why I'm proud to stand alongside Assemblymember Gabriel to ensure federal agents do not continue to terrorize immigrant communities and American citizens in our state," Carrillo said.

AB 1806 and AB 1807 were sponsored by the California Immigrant Policy Center and supported by a coalition of labor, immigrant rights, legal aid, civil rights, and faith organizations, according to Gabriel's office.

GUBERNATORIAL RACE

California candidates scheduled to square off in a debate tonight

By John Woolfolk
BAY AREA NEWS GROUP



Xavier Becerra, left, and Steve Hilton are candidates for the California gubernatorial race in 2026. **PHOTO OF BECERRA IS SCNG FILE PHOTO; PHOTO OF HILTON FROM ASSOCIATED PRESS**

The two men seeking to succeed Gov. Gavin Newsom as California's next governor will debate before a prime-time audience tonight in what is expected to be voters' only chance to see Democrat Xavier Becerra and Republican Steve Hilton spar one-on-one before the November election.

A race that before the June primary drew national news coverage, as more than half a dozen contending Democrats and a pair of leading Republicans jostled for the two lead spots that would advance them to the Nov. 3 general election, has since seen interest fade. Polls show Becerra leading Hilton by 20 percentage points or more, reflecting the state's lopsided party voter registration.

So why bother tuning in? Melinda Jackson, a San Jose State University Political Science professor with expertise in public opinion and voting behavior, points to the June 2024 debate between President Joe Biden and then-former President Donald Trump, in which Biden's unsteady performance led to his withdrawal from the race Trump ultimately won over Vice President Kamala Harris.

"Anything can happen, and unexpected things can happen," Jackson said. "Just look at Joe Biden, his debate performance cost him his presidential reelection."

Beyond the possibility of missing a rare debate faceplant, Jackson said this may be voters' only chance to evaluate the candidates in an unscripted environment that forces them to think on their feet. Given Becerra's substantial polling lead, it's unlikely he'd agree to another debate.

"It's the one chance that the voters have to see the candidates side by side, to compare them," Jackson said. "People watching get the visual cues. It's less scripted than the candidates' ads or appearances. They have to answer the tough questions. You get to see how they perform under pressure."

The debate will start at 6 p.m. and is being hosted by CNN in Los Angeles and will run one hour, with anchors Jake Tapper and Dana Bash serving as moderators. It will stream live for CNN's streaming and pay TV subscribers via CNN.com, CNN connected TV and mobile apps. CNN is offering streaming subscriptions for $51.99 a year or $6.99 a month.

In a state where registered Democrats outnumber Republicans by about two to one and that hasn't chosen a Republican governor since giving Arnold Schwarzenegger a second term 20 years ago, the debate is a make-or-break moment for Hilton, a former Fox News host and British political aide seeking his first elected office.

Hilton's experience as a TV commentator gives him an edge in a live television format — during the primary debates, he showed himself to be eloquent, well-spoken and quick on his feet. Becerra at times stumbled on his words during the debates, but also had his moments, like his zinger response to Democratic rival and former Los Angeles Mayor Antonio Villaraigosa: "Cálmate!" (calm down). And given his advantages in polling and party registration, he'll be under less pressure.

"Steve Hilton has demonstrated very strong communications skills in the campaign," said Dan Schnur, a politics professor at UC Berkeley's Institute of Governmental Studies, Pepperdine University and the University of Southern California. "If this were a deep red state like Oklahoma, he might be on a path to the governor's office. But in heavily Democratic California, it would take a major scandal or an unimaginable gaffe from Becerra to turn this into a competitive race."

Political professionals like Jackson, who will be among those tuning in, will scrutinize the candidates' debate strategies, how they play up their best qualities while exploiting their rival's vulnerabilities.

For Becerra, the front-runner, she said he needs to show how his extensive experience in politics — former congressman, state attorney general and health secretary in the Biden administration — will enable him to get things done, without coming across as wooden or dull.

"He wants to come across as looking executive, not being too boring," Jackson said.

For Hilton, she said, "he needs to convince people he has some actual reasonable or feasible ideas, rather than just critiquing the status quo."

Each candidate also has vulnerabilities their rivals will surely seek to exploit before a television audience.

For Hilton, Jackson said the biggest vulnerability is Trump, whose endorsement he's welcomed, and may well have won him the runner-up spot in the primary over Republican rivals, but who's been deeply unpopular with California voters overall, especially with an unresolved war with Iran choking off oil trade and spiking prices for gasoline and other goods. Expect Becerra to tie Hilton to Trump as often as possible she said.

"Trump is certainly a vulnerability for him," Jackson said.

Becerra's vulnerabilities center around California's underperformance under his party's governance, with some of the country's highest costs for housing, electricity, gasoline and other goods, and public schools and homelessness problems that have shown little improvement despite increased state spending on them.

"People are frustrated with the lack of progress on many of these issues," Jackson said, anticipating Hilton will try to show how "California Democrats have not been able to solve these issues."

Political experts also will take note of how the debate reflects broader shifts in party politics. Democrats have seen their party riven between more traditional Democrats like the outgoing governor, who is wrapping up his final term, and a far-left progressive wing touting socialism and a break in support for Israel that has seen gains across the country. Becerra hails from the traditional camp.

Republicans have often favored candidates whose experience is outside of government — like Schwarzenegger, the movie star, and also Trump, a real estate businessman before he first won the presidency in 2016.

Hilton would fit that mold, but is Trump wearing it out with California voters?

"Certainly there were times when outside candidates have been compelling, like Arnold Schwarzenegger," Jackson said. "Things have shifted from 20 years ago."

DUMPLING

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At left, Matt De Miglio, president of MPD Events, and Patrick Broderick, marketing director of Lunasia Dim Sum House, sample dumplings set for the Dumpling & Beer Fest at San Gabriel's Historic Mission District on Friday. **COURTESY OF MPD EVENTS**

free.

"We want this to feel like a celebration of San Gabriel and the incredible cultures, restaurants and businesses that make this community what it is. And my biggest piece of advice: come hungry," De Miglio added.

New this year is the Dumpling Bowl, where Southern California's dumpling makers go head-to-head in a culinary competition to crown a winner based on flavor, texture, creativity and presentation.

The perfect dumpling is all about the perfect ratio, organizers said.

"You want a wrapper that holds everything together, but doesn't overpower the filling, and then that filling needs to have a ton of flavor. Texture is huge too," De Miglio said.

Dumplings's iterations include potstickers, gyozas in Japan, mandus in Korea, pierogis in Eastern Europe, and empanadas and samosa in Latino and Southeast Asian communities.

De Miglio said there isn't a wrong way to eat a dumpling.

"That's actually one of the things I love about dumplings," he said. "Almost every culture has some version of a dumpling, and everyone has their own traditions around how they're made, served and eaten. Dip them, don't dip them, eat them in one bite, take your time, just enjoy them. Although with soup dumplings, maybe give them a second before you bite into them. I've learned that lesson the hard way."

A proud SGVer, De Miglio said he can list a Top 20 favorite kinds of dumplings.

"I love xiao long bao, har gow and siu mai. Lunasia is definitely one of my go-tos, and honestly, being in the San Gabriel Valley, we're completely spoiled. Some of the best dumplings in Southern California, and I'd argue anywhere, are right here," he said. And organizing the celebration has meant discovering even more local restaurants and trying new dishes.

Participating restaurants and vendors will serve their competing dumplings directly from their festival booths, and guests get the chance to purchase and try the entries throughout the evening. A panel of special guest judges will taste their way through the competition before one dumpling is crowned the 2026 Dumpling Bowl Champion, with the winner revealed live on stage during the festival.

A Journey Through Asia experience will feature four stops inspired by Tokyo, Shanghai, Manila and Hong Kong, four cities that Delta Airlines offers new direct routes from Los Angeles. The airline and Filipino Forces will sponsor the VIP experience. Delta SkyMiles Members will receive access to dedicated VIP lines at participating Journey Through Asia food vendors, offering an exclusive festival perk while exploring the four destinations.

Delta will also host the festival's VIP Lounge, creating an elevated home base for VIP guests during the evening.

The festival will also offer a broad lineup of Asian cuisine, street food, desserts and drinks from local restaurants and vendors. A Beer Garden will have a curated offering of non-alcoholic beverages and mocktails, too. Breweries and beverage producers at the event include Common Space, Brewery X, Grapevine Central, Stone Brewing, Whittier Brewing Company, Mt. Lowe Brewing, Cerveza Cito, and Cellador Ales.

Participating food vendors include Lunasia, Mad Dumplings, Dumplin' By Aro, The Dumpling Dream, Zindrew Wonton Shop, Rice Balls of Fire, Yum Long, Bubble Puffs and Stuff, Go Fusion N Grill, Coconut & Co. and more.

The nonprofit Asian Youth Center is the event's official charity partner. The San Gabriel-based center offers education, employment, social services, and community engagement programs.

For event information, visit dumplingandbeerfest.com.

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